

RIZWAN ZAFAR

Payments Product and Program Executive | Fintech Infrastructure | Emerging Markets

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Payments product and program executive working across complex technology and delivery environments since 2009. Currently Chief Product Officer at Simpaisa, leading product across payment gateway, pay-in, payout, cross-border, merchant onboarding, settlement, risk and compliance. Simpaisa publicly reports more than \$1B in annual GTV, 270M annual transactions, 150+ merchants and formal operations in five markets. Brings product judgment together with PMO discipline, partner management and regulated delivery.

CORE COMPETENCIES

PAYMENTS INFRASTRUCTURE	Gateway and orchestration pay-in and payout APIs card acquiring wallets DCB IBFT cross-border and FX settlement and reconciliation
PRODUCT LEADERSHIP	Strategy and roadmaps platform operating models merchant onboarding pricing and unit economics partner enablement product organization design
RISK AND CONTROLS	KYC and KYB AML and CFT sanctions screening fraud controls chargebacks PCI DSS ISO 27001 audit readiness
PROGRAM DELIVERY	PMO governance SteerCo and board reporting OKRs RAID management vendor governance multi-market launches transformation programs

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Chief Product Officer (acting CTO, 2024) | Simpaisa

Dubai | Aug 2020 - Present

- Own product strategy and roadmaps across payment gateway, pay-in, payout and cross-border product lines, working with executive, engineering, operations, risk and commercial teams.
- Built and scaled card acquiring, mobile-wallet, DCB, IBFT, voucher, bill-payment, QR, tokenization, payout and cross-border capabilities with local and global partners.
- Designed merchant onboarding across self-service flows, automated KYC and KYB, risk-tiered approval and category-based pricing for a platform serving 150+ merchants.
- Established product controls across fraud prevention, chargebacks, AML and CFT, transaction monitoring, settlement and reconciliation; supported PCI DSS Level 1 and ISO 27001 programs.
- Led multi-market expansion and platform delivery through a regulatory transition while carrying dual product and technology leadership responsibilities during 2024.
- Built the product organization from 2 to 8 product managers and led cross-functional delivery across product, engineering, operations, risk and compliance.

Project Manager, Payments Operations | Daraz (Alibaba Group)

Karachi | Mar 2020 - Aug 2020

- Ran payments operations and delivery governance across Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal and Myanmar during the COVID-driven volume surge.
- Coordinated reconciliation, settlement, payment compliance, fraud-rule management and vendor delivery across country teams.

Senior Product and Program Manager | Tapmad

Karachi | Jul 2017 - Mar 2020

- Owned OTT monetization and billing strategy; launched direct carrier billing across Pakistan's four major telecom operators and expanded wallet and card payment options.
- Led migration from high-cost carrier billing toward wallet and card rails, improving payment economics and subscription flexibility.

EARLIER PROGRAM AND PMO LEADERSHIP

PMO and Project Manager | Wing Logic

Dubai | Apr 2017 - Oct 2017

- Established PMO governance, portfolio reporting, risk tracking and executive cadence for a multi-project technology and engineering portfolio.

Assistant Manager, Projects | CIMKO / Nyumba Ya Akiba

DR Congo | May 2016 - Jan 2017

- Managed ERP and IT infrastructure initiatives in a greenfield industrial environment, coordinating vendors, procurement, schedule and operational handover.

Project Manager, PMO | DS Engineering Services

Karachi | Sep 2012 - Feb 2016

- Managed engineering-project portfolios and built reporting, controls and delivery governance across utilities and infrastructure programs.

Senior Planning Engineer | PESCO

Karachi | Jun 2009 - Aug 2012

- Planned and monitored power-infrastructure work, establishing the reliability and operational discipline that later shaped fintech product leadership.

EDUCATION

MIT Sloan School of Management - Certificate, Mastering Design Thinking Executive Program (2022)

University of Karachi - M.Sc. Applied Physics (2012); B.Sc. Physics, Statistics and Mathematics (2009)

CERTIFICATIONS

Project Management Professional (PMP), PMI | PMI Agile Certified Practitioner (PMI-ACP) | Certified Scrum Product Owner (CSPO) | Certified ScrumMaster (CSM) | COBIT 5 Foundation | ITIL v3 Foundation

SELECTED PROFESSIONAL FOCUS

- VP, Head or Director of Product - Payments Infrastructure
- Product leadership for payment networks, PSPs, acquiring, cross-border and regulated fintech
- Program and transformation leadership where product, controls, partners and delivery must operate as one system

PORTFOLIO AND CONTACT

Selected work and payments writing: rzifi.com

Book a 15-minute introduction: cal.com/rizwan-zafar-gws2uk/15min